encounter that he knew of his decision to join the covert organisation. From this, Abdul Ghaffar had surmised that Bhat was a senior figure in Al-Fatah. During a subsequent meeting with Zahgir, Ghaffar said, his speculation was confirmed. But Ghaffar, however, knew the names of only a few low-level Al-Fatah operatives. What the police did learn, was that all of Al-Fatah's senior members were close to a Srinagar *paan* shop owner, Mohammad Yusuf Mir. For all of Al-Fatah's careful security measures, its top leadership had been careless enough to patronise this *paan* shop. Mir was arrested and interrogated for several days and finally, on 16 January 1971, he cracked and told police officials of the Al-Fatah safe-house at Barsoo. Deputy Inspector General of Police, Pir Ghulam Hassan Shah personally led the raid, along with another officer who acquired much prominence thereafter —Deputy Superintendent of Police, A. M. Watali.

Nazir Ahmad Wani and Farooq Bhat were both in the Barsoo safe-house when the police arrived and both opened fire with their revolvers but were arrested alive. Watali kept the premises under surveillance, which led to the arrest of Fazl-ul-Haq Qureshi and Abdul Hai. Fazl-ul-Haq Qureshi's interrogation was to finally lead the police to Zahgir. In the course of the day, he confessed further and revealed another safe-house that had been established in Srinagar's Shahidgunj area, just before the Hazratbal robbery. This is where Zahgir was living. Watali also placed these premises under surveillance and soon after, Zahgir was arrested by two police teams, who burst into his top-floor room and disarmed him. From Zahgir, police investigators learned, for the first time, the details of the Pulwama dacoity, the existence of the political wing of Al-Fatah and its links with Beg.

The police also found a treasure trove of documentation on the organisational structure of Al-Fatah in the safe-house, along with some classified Indian military papers. Soon afterwards, a large cache of Pakistan-supplied Sten guns was recovered at Charar-e-Sharief. During his interrogation, Zahgir told the police that he had planned to initiate a series of kidnappings and assassinations when campaign for the upcoming 1971 general elections began. Zahgir, the police recorded, said that the hostages would have been kept at the Barsoo safe-house.